Vaikundar is said to have died in 1851 while still in his early forties, his body being entombed in the Swamithope *pathi*, the main temple of the cult, midway between Nagercoil and Kanyakumari. Every year in late January his followers celebrate his rebirth from the sea by gathering in great numbers to bathe beside the seashore temple of Tiruchendur.

By contrast, Kanjan Pillai, better known as Chattampi Swamikal, came from the upper end of the social scale, being the offspring of a Nambudiri father by a Nair mother. Born in 1853 and raised in modest circumstances outside Trivandrum, he had little formal education. He is said to have worked as a labourer and subsequently as a clerk before coming to the notice of a Brahmin who took him under his wing. He subsequently became a wanderer and mystic, travelling through Tamil Nadu exploring Christian and Muslim theology as well as studying under a number of *avaduta*s or Hindu sages. He returned to Kerala a committed reformer, joining with Narayana Guru, the son of an Ezhava peasant, to denounce the orthodoxy of the Nambudiris and the caste restrictions imposed by them.

Although as much religious as social reformers, these three Keralans each in their different ways helped to clear paths for the next generation of reformers – a generation dominated by the formidable Ayyan Kali, a member of the Pulayar ‘untouchable’ community who never learned to read or write yet led the first non-violent protests and organised the first mass demonstrations and strikes that blazed a trail for the great Mahatma, M. K. Gandhi.

Every road in Travancore had, in theory, been open to all since 1865. However, a subsequent legal ruling had made a distinction between public and private roads, allowing many temple authorities to claim that the roads closest to their temple were private, open to all, including Christians and Muslims, but not to the outcaste *avarna*s. It was this bizarre situation which led that remarkable Bengali reformer and